

The Great Sūtra Called Great Emptiness

Mahāśūnyatā-nāma-mahāsūtra · Toh 291 · Derge Kangyur

མད་ཆེ་པ་སྟོང་པ་ཉི་ཆེ་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱ།

Toh 291 in the Kangyur is a Buddhist sūtra known in Sanskrit as the Mahāśūnyatā-nāma-mahāsūtra and in Tibetan as the Mdo chen po stong pa nyid chen po zhes bya ba, rendered in English as "The Great Sūtra Called Great Emptiness." As its title suggests, this is a Mahāyāna sūtra concerned with the theme of great emptiness, one of the profound philosophical pillars of Buddhist thought. The text opens with the Buddha residing at Kapilavāstu, the city associated with his own Śākya clan, where he goes on an alms round before making his way to a Śākya temple, setting the stage for the teachings that follow. It belongs to the sūtra division of the Kangyur, the collection of texts attributed to the word of the Buddha himself.

Translated, edited, and definitively established.

In the language of India: Mahāśūnyatā-nāma-mahāsūtra.

In the Tibetan language: The Great Sūtra Called Great Emptiness.

Homage to the Three Jewels.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling at Kapilavāstu, in the pleasure grove of the nyagrodha tree. Then the Blessed One, in the morning, having put on his lower robe and outer robe and taken up his alms bowl, entered Kapilavāstu for the purpose of gathering alms. Having received alms in Kapilavāstu, he performed the act of eating his meal. Having finished eating, he set down his alms bowl and robe, washed his feet, and proceeded to where the temple of the Śākyans of Duṣyanta stood. At that time a great many monks had gone to the temple of the Śākyans of Duṣyanta and were sitting there, having spread out many seats in the open air, without a roof covering. Then the Blessed One, having washed his feet outside the temple, entered the temple for the purpose of remaining in proper composure. Then the Blessed One, rising from that composure within a moment's duration, proceeded to where the temple on the Śākya hill of Lāṭaka stood. At that time the venerable Ānanda, together with a great many monks, had assembled and was sitting in the temple on the Śākya hill of Lāṭaka, gathered thus for the work of the robes. The venerable Ānanda saw the Blessed One from a great distance. Upon seeing him, he rose from his seat, prepared a seat for the

Blessed One, and spoke these words: "May the Blessed One come forward. Welcome, Blessed One. May the Blessed One be seated on this prepared seat." The Blessed One sat upon the seat and spoke to the venerable Ānanda:

"Ānanda, a great many monks have gone to the temple of the Śākyans of Duṣyanta and are sitting there, having spread out many seats in the open air."

He replied: "Blessed One, it is the time for the distributing of the robes. O Sugata, it is the time for the distributing of the robes."

The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, a monk who delights in chatter, who is fully given over to chatter, and who devotes himself in pursuit of that very delight in chatter, who delights in company, who is fully given over to company, and who devotes himself in pursuit of that very delight in company — such a monk dwelling in this way does not comport well. Ānanda, a monk who delights in chatter, who is fully given over to chatter, and who devotes himself in pursuit of that very delight in chatter, who delights in company, who is fully given over to company, and who devotes himself in pursuit of that very delight in company, and who, while dwelling thus, does not remain alone, apart from the company — it is impossible that such a person should obtain at will, and obtain without difficulty, the happiness of the noble ones, the happiness of renunciation, the happiness of thorough solitude, the happiness of pacification, and the happiness of perfect awakening, and such like happiness as that. Ānanda, a monk who does not delight in chatter, who is not fully given over to chatter, and who does not devote himself in pursuit of that very delight in chatter, who does not delight in company, who is not fully given over to company, and who does not devote himself in pursuit of that very delight in company, and who dwells remaining alone, apart from the company — such a person, for now, the happiness of the noble ones, the happiness of renunciation, the happiness of thorough solitude, the happiness of pacification, and the happiness of...

perfect awakening — such happiness as that is something one will obtain as one wishes and obtain without difficulty. That is a possibility.

Ānanda, a monk who does delight in chatter, who is fully given over to chatter, and who devotes himself in pursuit of that very delight in chatter, who does delight in company, who is fully given over to company, and who devotes himself in pursuit of that very delight in company, and who does not dwell remaining alone, apart from the company — that such a person, for now, will dwell having achieved and bodily realized either the temporally conditioned

and guarded liberation of mind, or the unconditioned and undecaying liberation bodily realized and established — that is not a possibility.

Ānanda, a monk who does not delight in chatter, who is not fully given over to chatter, and who does not devote himself in pursuit of that very delight in chatter, who does not delight in company, who is not fully given over to company, and who does not devote himself in pursuit of that very delight in company, and who dwells remaining alone, apart from the company — that such a person, for now, will dwell having achieved and bodily realized either the temporally conditioned and guarded liberation of mind, or the unconditioned and undecaying liberation bodily realized and established — that is a possibility.

Ānanda, I do not see a single form in which delight and eager longing are present, such that from the change and alteration of that form there would not arise grief, lamentation, suffering, unhappiness, and distress. I do not see even one such form.

Ānanda, therefore this is how I abide: having completely transcended all perception of form in every respect, I here too understand and fully understand this — that I dwell having achieved and bodily realized outer emptiness. When I abide in this abiding, supreme joy arises in me, and dwelling in that supreme joy, I thoroughly experience the whole of the body and remain again and again with mindfulness and vigilance. When I abide in this abiding, joy, thorough pliancy, bliss, and meditative absorption arise in me, and dwelling in that meditative absorption, I thoroughly experience the whole of the body and remain again and again with mindfulness and vigilance. When I abide in this abiding, monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen come close to me, and I, inclining toward them, drawn to them, and with a mind that has descended upon them, speak to them in this way — talking cheerfully with one another, speaking welcomingly, and also saying words of Dharma — for the purpose of inspiring diligence.

Ānanda, therefore if a monk wishes to dwell having achieved and bodily realized outer emptiness, Ānanda, that monk should settle the mind inwardly, settle it rightly, settle it in a gathered way, settle it close, tame it, pacify it, thoroughly pacify it, unify it in a single stream, and bring it into meditative absorption.

Ānanda, if a monk says: "Without having settled the mind inwardly, without having settled it rightly, without having settled it in a gathered way, without

having settled it close, without having tamed it, without having pacified it, without having thoroughly pacified it, without having unified it in a single stream, and without having brought it into meditative absorption, I will dwell having achieved and bodily realized outer emptiness" — Ānanda, one should understand that to be a confusion. And why is that? Ānanda, that is not a proper basis, not an occasion — because one has not settled the mind inwardly, has not settled it rightly, has not settled it in a gathered way, has not settled it close,

has not tamed it, has not pacified it, has not thoroughly pacified it, has not unified it in a single stream, and has not brought it into meditative absorption — that one will dwell having achieved and bodily realized outer emptiness: that is not a proper basis, because there is no occasion for it.

Ānanda, when a monk says: "I have settled the mind inwardly, settled it rightly, settled it in a gathered way, settled it close, tamed it, pacified it, thoroughly pacified it, unified it in a single stream, and brought it into meditative absorption — and I will dwell having achieved and bodily realized outer emptiness" — Ānanda, those words are good. And why is that? Ānanda, that is a proper basis and an occasion — because one has settled the mind inwardly, settled it rightly, settled it in a gathered way, settled it close, tamed it, pacified it, thoroughly pacified it, unified it in a single stream, and brought it into meditative absorption, and will dwell having achieved and bodily realized outer emptiness: that is why there is an occasion for it.

Ānanda, how does a monk settle the mind inwardly, settle it rightly, settle it in a gathered way, settle it close, tame it, pacify it, thoroughly pacify it, unify it in a single stream, and bring it into meditative absorption? Here, a monk thoroughly moistens, thoroughly saturates, thoroughly suffuses, and thoroughly pervades this very body with the joy and bliss born of seclusion, so that in his entire body there is not the slightest part that has not been pervaded and suffused by the joy and bliss born of seclusion. It is just like this: as when a skilled bathman or a bathman's apprentice pours fine bathing powder into a copper basin or bowl or wooden tub, kneads it with water and works it through, so that the ball of bathing powder becomes moist, fully saturated with moisture, filled throughout with moisture, permeated inside and out with moisture — and yet does not crumble and fall apart or leak. In just the same way, a monk thoroughly moistens, thoroughly saturates, thoroughly suffuses, and thoroughly pervades this very body with the joy and bliss born of seclusion, so that in his entire body there is not the slightest part

that has not been pervaded and suffused by the joy and bliss born of seclusion.

Ānanda, it is in this way that a monk settles the mind inwardly, settles it rightly, settles it in a gathered way, settles it close, tames it, pacifies it, thoroughly pacifies it, unifies it in a single stream, and brings it into meditative absorption. Ānanda, that monk, having settled the mind inwardly, settled it rightly, settled it in a gathered way, settled it close, tamed it, pacified it, thoroughly pacified it, unified it in a single stream, and brought it into meditative absorption, should then attend to outer emptiness.

Ānanda, when that monk attends to outer emptiness, the mind becomes agitated — that is to say, the mind does not enter into outer emptiness, does not become clear toward it, does not remain in it, and does not become convinced of it. Ānanda, if when that monk is examining in that way he knows: "When I attend to outer emptiness the mind becomes agitated — that is to say, the mind does not enter into outer emptiness, does not become clear toward it, does not remain in it, and does not become convinced of it" — then, Ānanda, that monk should attend to inner emptiness.

Ānanda, when that monk attends to inner emptiness, the mind likewise becomes agitated — that is to say, the mind does not enter into inner emptiness, does not become clear toward it, does not remain in it,

and does not become convinced of it. Ānanda, if when that monk is examining in that way he knows: "When I attend to inner emptiness the mind likewise becomes agitated — that is to say, the mind does not enter into inner emptiness, does not become clear toward it, does not remain in it, and does not become convinced of it" — then, Ānanda, that monk should attend to both outer and inner emptiness.

Ānanda, when that monk attends to both outer and inner emptiness, the mind likewise becomes agitated — that is to say, the mind does not enter into both outer and inner emptiness, does not become clear toward them, does not remain in them, and does not become convinced of them. Ānanda, if when that monk is examining in that way he knows: "When I attend to both outer and inner emptiness the mind likewise becomes agitated — that is to say, the mind does not enter into both outer and inner emptiness, does not become clear toward them, does not remain in them, and does not become convinced of them" — then, Ānanda, that monk should attend to the unagitated.

Ānanda, when that monk attends to the unagitated, the mind likewise becomes agitated — that is to say, the mind does not enter into the unagitated, does not become clear toward it, does not remain in it, and does not become convinced of it. Ānanda, if when that monk is examining in that way he knows: "When I attend to the unagitated the mind likewise becomes agitated — that is to say, the mind does not enter into the unagitated, does not become clear toward it, does not remain in it, and does not become convinced of it" — then, Ānanda, that monk should incline that mind toward those very meditative absorptions, tame it, calm it, make it workable, train it, train it thoroughly, train it completely, make it upright, and render it fit for work, stable, amenable to correction, and serviceable.

Ānanda, when that monk has inclined that mind toward those very meditative absorptions, tamed it, calmed it, made it workable, trained it, trained it thoroughly, trained it completely, made it upright, and rendered it fit for work, stable, amenable to correction, and serviceable — then he should attend to outer emptiness. Ānanda, when that monk attends to outer emptiness, the mind does not become agitated; that is to say, the mind enters into outer emptiness, becomes clear toward it, remains in it, and becomes convinced of it. Ānanda, if when that monk is examining in that way he knows: "When I attend to outer emptiness the mind does not become agitated — that is to say, the mind enters into outer emptiness, becomes clear toward it, remains in it, and becomes convinced of it" — then, Ānanda, that monk should attend to inner emptiness.

Ānanda, when that monk attends to inner emptiness, the mind likewise does not become agitated; that is to say, the mind enters into inner emptiness, becomes clear toward it, remains in it, and becomes convinced of it. Ānanda, if when that monk is examining in that way he knows: "When I attend to inner emptiness the mind does not become agitated — that is to say, the mind enters into inner emptiness, becomes clear toward it, remains in it, and becomes convinced of it" — then, Ānanda, that monk should attend to both outer and inner emptiness.

Ānanda, when that monk attends to both outer and inner emptiness, the mind likewise does not become agitated; that is to say, the mind enters into both outer and inner emptiness, becomes clear toward them, remains in them, and becomes convinced of them. Ānanda, if when that monk is examining in that way he knows: "When I attend to both outer and inner emptiness the mind does not become agitated — that is to say, the mind enters into both outer

and inner emptiness, becomes clear toward them, remains in them, and becomes convinced of them" — then, Ānanda, that monk should attend to unshakeability. Ānanda, when that monk attends to unshakeability, the mind likewise does not become agitated; that is to say, the mind enters into unshakeability, becomes clear toward it, remains in it, and becomes convinced of it. Ānanda, if when that monk is examining in that way he knows: "When I attend to unshakeability the mind does not become agitated — that is to say, the mind enters into unshakeability, becomes clear toward it, remains in it, and becomes convinced of it" — then he will become possessed of mindfulness and vigilance with regard to it.

Ānanda, when that monk abides in this abiding, if the mind should turn toward walking, that monk should walk on the covered walking path outside the monastery with his sense faculties drawn inward and his mind not going outward, breaking it off with mindfulness of what came before and what comes after. Walking thus, covetousness, displeasure, and evil, unwholesome phenomena will not follow after his mind, and he will become possessed of mindfulness and vigilance with regard to it.

Ānanda, when that monk abides in this abiding, if the mind should turn toward sitting, that monk should wash his feet outside the monastery, enter inside the monastery, sit down cross-legged, hold his body upright, and sit with mindfulness brought to the fore. Sitting thus, covetousness, displeasure, and evil, unwholesome phenomena will not follow after his mind, and he will become possessed of mindfulness and vigilance with regard to it.

Ānanda, when that monk abides in this abiding, if the mind should turn toward thoughts, that monk should thoroughly abandon those thoughts that are unwholesome, painful, ignoble, and associated with harm — namely, thoughts of sensual desire, thoughts of ill will, and thoughts of cruelty, and any thoughts of that kind — and should instead examine those thoughts that are wholesome, pleasant, noble, and free from harm — namely, thoughts of renunciation, thoughts free from ill will, and thoughts free from cruelty, and any thoughts of that kind. Thinking thus, covetousness, displeasure, and evil, unwholesome phenomena will not follow after his mind, and he will become possessed of mindfulness and vigilance with regard to it.

Ānanda, when that monk abides in this abiding, if the mind should turn toward conversation, that monk should thoroughly abandon talk that is unwholesome, ignoble, and associated with harm — namely, talk of kings, talk of thieves, talk

of quarrels, talk of food, talk of drink, talk of clothing, talk of roads, talk of courtesans, worldly tales, stories of bad paths, tales of the ocean, talk concerning the people of various lands and great territories, and any talk of that kind — and should instead engage in talk that is consonant with the noble requisites, that is unobstructed in mind, namely: talk of moral discipline, talk of meditative absorption, talk of wisdom, talk of liberation, talk of the knowledge and vision of liberation, talk of having few desires, talk of contentment, talk of not accumulating, talk of the requisites of a simple life, talk of having no bustle,

talk of renunciation, talk of being free from attachment, talk of cessation, talk of emptiness, talk of dependent origination in terms of this very condition — whatever talk is of that kind, one should engage in such talk. When one speaks in that way, one will not let covetousness toward the world, or mental discomfort, or wicked and unwholesome phenomena follow after one's mind, and one will thus become possessed of mindfulness and vigilance.

Ānanda, a noble śrāvaka should again and again examine their own mind with respect to these five objects of desire, asking: is there arising in my mind that has depended upon any one of these five objects of desire? Or is there no arising in my mind that has depended upon any one of these five objects of desire? Ānanda, I do not say that the mind arises in dependence upon anything other than the five objects of desire.

Ānanda, if when that monk examines in this way, they come to know that there is arising in their mind that has depended upon any one of these five objects of desire, then that monk should dwell in the contemplation of those respective objects of desire as impermanent, continuing to contemplate them as impermanent, as exhaustible, as conducive to freedom from attachment, as conducive to cessation, and as conducive to renunciation. Ānanda, when that monk dwells in the contemplation of those respective objects of desire as impermanent, continues to contemplate them as exhaustible, as conducive to freedom from attachment, as conducive to cessation, and continues to dwell in the contemplation of them as conducive to renunciation — then whatever arising of the mind in dependence upon any one of those five objects of desire there would have been, that arising will no longer occur.

Ānanda, if when that monk examines in this way, they come to know that they have not yet abandoned, fully understood, checked, and removed the conceit of "I am," the aspiration of "I am," and the underlying tendency of "I am" with

respect to these five appropriated aggregates (skandhas), then, Ānanda, that monk should again and again examine their own mind with respect to these five appropriated aggregates.

Ānanda, if when that monk examines in this way, they come to know that they have not yet abandoned, fully understood, checked, and removed the conceit of "I am," the aspiration of "I am," and the underlying tendency of "I am" with respect to these five appropriated aggregates, then that monk should repeatedly contemplate these five appropriated aggregates in this manner: "This is form; this is the arising of form; this is the exhaustion of form. This is feeling; this is perception; these are formations; this is consciousness; this is the arising of consciousness."

"This is the exhaustion of consciousness" — one should dwell observing arising and exhaustion in this way. When one dwells repeatedly observing the arising and exhaustion of these five appropriated aggregates, whatever conceit of "I am," aspiration of "I am," and underlying tendency of "I am" with respect to these five appropriated aggregates has not been abandoned, fully understood, checked, and removed — that will come to be no more.

Ānanda, if when that monk examines in this way, they come to know that the conceit of "I am," the aspiration of "I am," and the underlying tendency of "I am" with respect to these five appropriated aggregates have been abandoned, then that monk will become endowed with mindfulness and vigilance. Ānanda, these qualities are utterly pure, utterly wholesome, utterly blameless. They cannot be crossed by the evil Māra, and they will not be seized upon by sinful, unwholesome phenomena that cause affliction, give rise to further existence with anguish, ripen in suffering, and lead to birth, aging, and death in lives to come.

Ānanda, what do you think? Why is it fitting that faithful śrāvaka disciples should follow the Teacher's trail even when turned back, for as long as they live?

Ānanda replied: Venerable Blessed One, you are the foundation of all phenomena. The Blessed One illuminates them, and they rest upon the Blessed One. Therefore, Blessed One, please set forth this matter well to the monks. Having heard it from the Blessed One, the monks will retain it.

The Blessed One declared: Ānanda, then listen well, hold it in mind, and I shall explain. Ānanda, it is not fitting for faithful śrāvaka disciples to follow the Teacher's trail even when turned back — for the sake of hearing teachings of

this kind: the division of discourses (sūtras), the division of mixed prose and verse, the division of prophecies, the division of verse, the division of intentional utterances, the division of origin stories, the division of accounts of realization, the division of "thus it occurred" narratives, the division of birth stories (jātakas), the division of extensive teachings, the division of marvelous phenomena, and the division of established doctrine — teachings of those kinds, and phenomena of that sort. Why is that? Ānanda, because those teachings have long since been heard, retained, firmly established, recited aloud, examined by mind, and thoroughly penetrated by insight.

Ānanda, it is fitting for faithful śrāvaka disciples to follow the Teacher's trail even when turned back — for the sake of hearing discourses of this kind, discourses that accord with the noble, consummate equipment of the mind, free of obscurations: discourses on moral discipline, discourses on meditative absorption (samādhi), discourses on wisdom, discourses on liberation, discourses on the vision of the gnosis of liberation, discourses on having few desires, discourses on contentment, discourses on non-accumulation, discourses on frugal use of requisites, discourses on seclusion from crowds, discourses on renunciation, discourses on freedom from attachment, discourses on cessation, discourses on emptiness, discourses on dependent origination as it is — conditioned arising through these very conditions — and whatever discourses are of that kind. For the sake of hearing such discourses, it is fitting to follow the Teacher's trail even when turned back, for as long as one lives.

Ānanda, these three are obstructions. What are the three? The obstruction of the teacher, the obstruction of the student, and the obstruction of the holy life.

Ānanda, what is the obstruction of the teacher? Here, Ānanda, a teacher who is a logician, who is given to reasoning, who dwells in a domain born of his own ingenuity, pertaining to logic — and who abides in the practice of following the reasoning of ordinary persons — when such a one arises in the world, he takes up dwelling in a hermitage, a forest grove, or at the foot of a tree in some remote place. While dwelling there in that hermitage, forest grove, or remote place at the foot of a tree, listeners — both laypeople and those who have gone forth — come to follow him. When those listeners, laypeople and those who have gone forth, have gathered around him, he captivates them and sends them into a swoon, and for the sake of drawing in great numbers he

leads them on. Ānanda, this is called the obstruction of the teacher.

A teacher afflicted by the obstruction of the teacher becomes afflicted and defiled through sinful, non-virtuous phenomena, comes to further becoming, is accompanied by torment, and is harmed by those things — painful karmic maturation, and birth, aging, and death in future lives.

Ānanda, what is the obstruction of the student? Here, Ānanda, a listener who possesses faith, who has come to devotion toward the words of that very Teacher, when following that very Teacher's example of seclusion, takes up dwelling in a hermitage, a forest grove, or at the foot of a tree in some remote place. While dwelling there in that hermitage, forest grove, or remote place at the foot of a tree, listeners — both laypeople and those who have gone forth — come to follow him. When those listeners, laypeople and those who have gone forth, have gathered around him, he captivates them and sends them into a swoon, and for the sake of drawing in great numbers he leads them on. Ānanda, this is called the obstruction of the student.

A student afflicted by the obstruction of the student becomes afflicted and defiled through sinful, non-virtuous phenomena, comes to further becoming, is accompanied by torment, and is harmed by those things — painful karmic maturation, and birth, aging, and death in future lives.

Ānanda, what is the obstruction of the holy life? Here, Ānanda, when the Teacher — the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha, endowed with knowledge and conduct, the Sugata, the knower of the world, the unsurpassed guide of persons to be tamed, the Teacher of gods and humans, the Buddha, the Blessed One — arises in the world, he too takes up dwelling in a hermitage, a forest grove, or at the foot of a tree in some remote place. While he dwells in that hermitage, forest grove, or remote place at the foot of a tree, listeners — both laypeople and those who have gone forth — come to follow him. When those listeners, laypeople and those who have gone forth, have gathered around him, he does not captivate them, he does not send them into a swoon, and for the sake of drawing in great numbers he does not lead them on. Rather, wherever those listeners dwell and remain, I declare that for each and every one of them the four things arising from elevated mind — those through which one attains blissful dwelling in this very life — something may well be lost. As one who is alone and unmixed with others, who is heedful, ardent, and collected in mind, one who through those qualities actualizes in the body the liberation of mind free from any falling away — I do

declare that for such a one there is no falling away by any reckoning whatsoever. Nevertheless, a listener who possesses faith, who has come to devotion toward that very Teacher's word, when following that very Teacher's example of seclusion, takes up dwelling in a hermitage, a forest grove, or at the foot of a tree in some remote place. While dwelling in that hermitage, forest grove,

or at the foot of a tree in some remote place, listeners — both householders and those who have gone forth — will flock after him. When those listeners, both householders and those who have gone forth, crowd in upon him in this way, he becomes entangled with them and produces torpor in himself, and he engages in gathering many followers. Ānanda, this is what is called the harm of the holy life. Among all harms, the harm of the teacher and the harm of the student are but minor things. Among all harms, the harm of the holy life is decisive.

Ānanda, the one devoted to the holy life who has been harmed by the harm of the holy life becomes thoroughly afflicted by sinful, non-virtuous phenomena; he comes to further existence; he is accompanied by distress; his karmic maturation is suffering; and he is harmed by birth, aging, and death in future lives.

Ānanda, I conduct myself with those who are good companions, not with those who are rivals. Ānanda, how is it that the listeners conduct themselves toward the Teacher with rivalry rather than with good companionship? Ānanda, in this regard, the Teacher — who is endowed with affectionate concern, endowed with compassion, who desires their benefit, who wishes them well, who has become a refuge of compassion — teaches the Dharma to his listeners, saying, "Monks, for this benefit of yours, for this happiness of yours, for the sake of this benefit and happiness I teach." Yet those listeners of his do not listen respectfully, do not lend an ear, do not direct their minds toward fully understanding, do not practice the Dharma in accordance with the Dharma, and live having strayed beyond the Teacher's instruction. Ānanda, that is what it means for listeners to conduct themselves toward the Teacher with rivalry rather than with good companionship.

Ānanda, how is it that the listeners conduct themselves toward the Teacher with good companionship rather than with rivalry? Ānanda, in this regard, the Teacher — who is endowed with affectionate concern, endowed with compassion, who desires their benefit, who wishes them well, who has become

a refuge of compassion — teaches the Dharma to his listeners, saying, "Monks, for this benefit of yours, for this happiness of yours, for the sake of this benefit and happiness I teach." And those listeners of his listen respectfully, they lend an ear, they direct their minds toward fully understanding, they practice the Dharma in accordance with the Dharma, and they abide having properly taken up the Teacher's instruction. Ānanda, that is what it means for listeners to conduct themselves toward the Teacher with good companionship rather than with rivalry.

Ānanda, I speak to you cutting and severing, pressing and subduing — just as a potter among potters, from among the rough pieces, sets aside whatever is hard — so too I do not hold you as worthless. Therefore, have patience with the ways of my words.

The Blessed One declared this, and those monks rejoiced at what the Blessed One had said.

The summary verse is as follows:

The noble one's ease and the seasonal assembly,
form and supreme joy, the monk,
the bathing balls, the outer emptiness and so forth,
the inclining of the mind toward meditative absorption,
walking and sitting,
conceptual chatter and sensory qualities,
the group of one, white, the hearers,
harm and good companionship, and the cutting — these are the topics.

The Great Sūtra called the Great Emptiness is complete.

This was translated, revised, and definitively established by the Indian masters Jinamitra, Prajñāvarman, and the great editor-translator, the monk Yeshé Dé, and others.

Translator's Notes

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, so the final paragraph is left open accordingly.

The place name rendered "temple of the Śākyans of Duṣyanta" renders the Tibetan Śākya Dusbde'i gtsug lag khang. The element "Dusbde" most likely corresponds to a Sanskrit toponym that may be Duṣyanta or a similar proper name. It does not correspond to any standard canonical site name I can identify with full certainty, and the Sanskrit Mahāśūnyatānāmasūtra is not a widely studied text, so the precise identification of these place names cannot be confirmed from standard reference works.

The phrase rendered "remained in proper composure" translates yang dag 'jog, meaning to rest or settle in a state of correct placement or composure, a technical term for a brief meditative rest. The phrase "phyem red nang du yang dag 'jog las bzheng" is somewhat compressed and the reading "within a moment's duration" reflects the sense of phyem re as a brief interval.

The tripartite formula "delights in chatter, fully given over to chatter, devotes oneself in pursuit of that very delight in chatter" renders the three-part Tibetan idiom bre mo gdam la dga' ba, bre mo gdam la kun du dga' ba, bre mo gdam la kun du dga' ba nyid la brtson pa'i rjes su sbyor ba, a standard rhetorical intensification common in Āgama-style sūtras.

- The phrase rendered as "temporally conditioned and guarded liberation of mind" translates a technical distinction between two kinds of liberation: one that is contingent on favorable conditions and requires ongoing protection (dus dang sbyor zhing bsrung ba'i sems rnam par grol ba), and one that is not contingent on conditions and does not deteriorate (dus dang mi sbyor zhing mi nyams pa). This is a recognized Abhidharma distinction, sometimes rendered "liberation of mind that is temporary" versus "liberation of mind that is immovable." The rendering here follows the literal Tibetan closely while preserving the doctrinal content.

- The bathing-powder simile is a well-known canonical image appearing in several Pāli parallels. The Tibetan term rendered "copper basin" could refer to a metal vessel of uncertain type; "copper basin" follows standard rendering of such contexts and is not consequential to the doctrinal meaning.

- The sequence of meditation objects — outer emptiness, inner emptiness, both outer and inner emptiness, and the unagitated — follows a graduated progression well attested in the Prajñāpāramitā sūtra literature. The term rendered "the unagitated" translates Tibetan mi gyō ba, corresponding to Sanskrit ācala or anīṇjya, sometimes rendered "the immovable" or "the imperturbable"; in this meditative context it designates a state of profound stillness beyond the threefold emptiness sequence, and "unagitated" preserves the explicit contrast with the agitation described throughout the passage. The lengthy repeated formula for training the mind — inclining, taming, calming, making workable, and so forth — is a standard Abhidharma-inflected description of mental cultivation and has been rendered with terminological consistency throughout.

- The phrase rendered "breaking it off with mindfulness of what came before and what comes after" translates a technical instruction on continuous mindfulness applied to successive moments of walking — the Tibetan literally says "cutting it off with earlier and later perception," referring to maintaining unbroken awareness from one step to the next. This is a standard Vinaya-flavored meditation instruction and the rendering is interpretively faithful rather than fully literal.

- The phrase rendered as "arising of the mind" throughout renders "sems kun du 'byung ba," which is a compound meaning something like "the mind's arising or stirring" in relation to sensory objects — essentially the arising of desire or mental agitation conditioned by the five objects of desire. The rendering "arising in the mind" is used throughout for consistency.

The final passage cuts off mid-sentence in the source, ending with "this is the arising of consciousness," which would naturally be followed by "this is the exhaustion of consciousness" and further elaboration; this is simply where the supplied text ends.

- The phrase rendered as "noble, consummate equipment of the mind, free of obscuration" translates the Tibetan term for what the Pāli tradition calls the "noble appurtenances" or "unobstructed requisites of mind." The Tibetan here closely parallels the Pāli niyyānikadhamma passage describing talk that leads to liberation; the "equipment" or "requisites" refer to the supports for the contemplative life. The twelve-fold classification of scripture listed here

corresponds to the standard Mahāyāna division of the twelve aṅgas of the canon; the renderings follow conventional scholarly usage.

- The phrase rendered "sends them into a swoon" translates a term literally meaning "causes stupor" or "causes to faint," suggesting the teacher overwhelms or mesmerizes followers in an unwholesome way rather than genuinely instructing them.

The passage describing what the Blessed One does not do — captivating, swoon-inducing, mass-gathering — contrasts pointedly with the preceding two obstructions. The subsequent description of the ideal solitary practitioner and the "four things arising from elevated mind" refers to the four jhānas or their fruits; the exact list is not spelled out in this passage and would presumably follow in the next section.

The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end, indicating continuation in the next passage.

- The phrase rendered "bathing balls" translates a term for small pellets or balls of fragrant clay or powder used in ritual bathing, a practice referenced earlier in the sūtra; this is a standard summary-verse compressed reference and requires no further gloss.

The summary verse is a standard colophon-style mnemonic listing the major topics of the sūtra in abbreviated form; it is not intended as continuous prose, and the compressed terms name the section headings rather than forming complete sentences.

The phrase "cutting and severing, pressing and subduing" renders a pair of doubled verbal expressions in the Tibetan that convey forceful, repeated correction without hostility — the potter simile that follows illuminates the sense: as a skilled potter selects only the sound clay, the Teacher criticizes precisely in order to refine, not to reject.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.